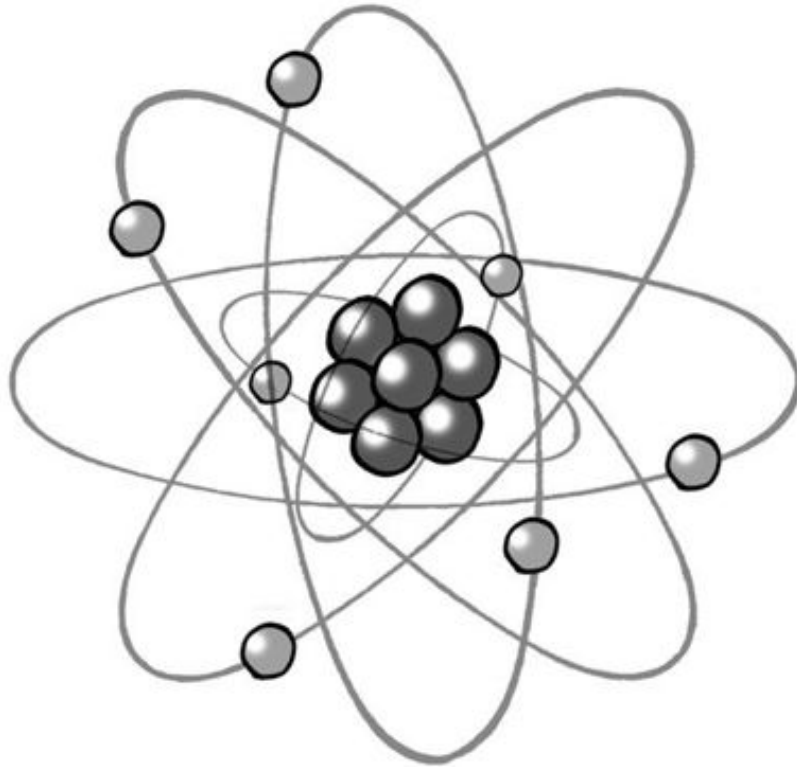


Philosophy and science



Throughout much of the history of philosophy, there was no such thing as science in its modern form: in fact, it was from philosophical enquiry that modern science has evolved. The questions that metaphysics set out to answer about the structure and substance of the universe prompted theories that later became the foundations of ‘natural philosophy’, the precursor of what we now call physics. The process of rational argument, meanwhile, underpins the ‘scientific method’.

Since the 18th century, many of the original questions of metaphysics have been answered by observation, experiment and measurement, and philosophy appeared to be redundant in these areas. Philosophers have since changed their focus to examine science itself. Some, like Hume, challenged the validity of inductive reasoning in science (see [The problem of induction](#)), while others sought to clarify the meaning of terms used by science, opening up a 'philosophy of science' that considers areas such as scientific ethics and the way science makes progress.